



Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). He realised that India's rapid growth as an industrial power would demand management skills of a higher order. He, therefore, helped establish the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) in Ahmedabad, one of our most famous management institutes and a pioneer in this field. He was also the institute's director till 1965.

In 1957, there was a major international cooperative programme called International Geophysical Year (IGY). When Sputnik I was launched by the USSR, Sarabhai was quite excited about the opportunities for research that had then opened up. His visits to MIT made him aware of the potential of space science and technology for economic and social development in sectors like communications, meteorology, remote sensing and disaster management. Sarabhai realised that the space age was the new age and he wanted India to benefit from it. Many do not realise the first television

these scientists were visionaries, who converted their dreams to realities, and thus, opened up huge areas of present-day national endeavour.

There are other examples of centres of excellence, some of which came about differently. Take the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). In 1942-43, a development committee was appointed under the chairmanship of Sir Joseph Bhore. One of its major recommendations was to set up an apex institute for postgraduate education and research. This institution—the dream of two great personalities, Nehru and Rajkumari Amrit Kaur—has not only provided selfless service to the nation, but in spite of the stress of patient load, has managed to conduct high quality medical research. Being close to several societal functions and under the purview of bureaucratic and political authority, AIIMS has been subjected to much buffeting. Though it has become a role model and trailblazer, for how long it will remain so is difficult to say in the light of the interference it has been subjected to.



The moot question is: will these institutions of excellence continue to be as revered when their visionaries are no longer around?

programmes shown in India were not the present day “commercials” but *Krishi Darshan* for farmers. With this background, Sarabhai grew India's space programme, creating many institutions of excellence—for example the complex in Thiruvananthapuram, now referred to as Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre. His vision was ably converted to reality by scientists like Satish Dhawan and Brahm Prakash. It is truly a joy to watch a launch at the Satish Dhawan Sriharikota Centre where technology is wholly science-based. All

Take another gleaming pillar of modern India. In September 1944, Sir Ardeshir Dalal, director of Tata Iron and Steel Co Ltd (TISCO) visited the United States. On his return, he made an announcement that an Indian IIT would be set up. By the 1961 Act of Parliament, the IITs became institutions of national importance. Today, a B.Tech from IIT and an MBA from IIM are the most sought after graduates in Indian, and often global industry. A huge number of people aspire to be a part of these institutes. When one looks at the number of students admitted, compared to the aspirants, it is clear that we can have many more IITs. But this would have to be done without lowering the quality of the education of these institutes. An attempt at this has now been made by increasing the number of IITs, and also increasing the number of seats in the existing institutions. This can only be possible if the basic autonomy of an educational institution is preserved.

We have created institutions in a whole variety of fields, of which we can be truly proud. The question that we have been facing is: will these institutions continue to be as revered when their visionaries are no longer around? Sri K.S. Krishnan, Raman's disciple and a well-known physicist, was fond of a Tamil saying, “Only the learned can recognise the learned”. We have the responsibility to ensure that such institutions—our valuable inheritance—continue to develop as role models and inspire present day national endeavour.

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